Hungry Eyes

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41412531.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Gen

Fandom:
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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta (She-Ra)

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Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Post-Episode: s05e05 Save the Cat, Idiots in Love, Slice of Life, Character Study, Catra is a good friend, That Felt Weird To Say, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Everyone Needs Therapy, POV Bow (She-Ra)

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by Paganaidd

Summary

Catra's death was going to devastate Adora. Bow only hoped grief wouldn't cripple her in the fight against Horde Prime. He hated himself for being so selfish; he tried to think of anything comforting to say but came up empty. And then...well…he was not at all sure what happened.

Catra coughed. "Hey, Adora." For a heartbeat, she looked genuinely content,

Catra settles in on Darla.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Darla

Somewhere in Space

A short time after Save the Cat

Bow would have voted against going back for Catra when Adora first mentioned it if either Glimmer or Adora had asked his opinion. But they didn't. He should have said something. He *would* have if he knew what they were walking into.

"I know Catra's done a lot of bad things and hurt a lot of people," Adora told Glimmer, anticipating an argument, "and it's crazy and dangerous and…."

"You want to go back for her?" Glimmer interrupted gently.

Adora nodded, the very picture of misery. She always had a hard time hiding her feelings, but this raw grief was new. Glimmer agreed without hesitation, and Adora lit up with joy. Bow couldn't find it in himself to object. Adora *never* asked for anything for herself. That, more than anything, made Bow keep quiet about his reservations.

It had been a terrible decision. The whole rescue had been a shitshow that they would not have survived if She Ra had not turned up.

When She Ra gave Catra's unconscious body to him, he was shocked at how light her dead weight was. It was true that he'd put on some muscle and a little height since that time they captured Catra, but she was much thinner than he remembered. He could feel every rib and the sharp bones of her spine. A

wheeze rattled in her chest, and bloody foam spotted her lips. Although her breathing sounded increasingly wet, she did not even cough.

As gently as he could, Bow laid the injured woman on the bridge's floor; she seemed to rouse a little. Her eyes opened, gazing sightlessly past him.

" ‘dor-a?" she gasped around the fluids that choked her. Her eyes slid shut again.

Taking care not to aggravate her injuries more than necessary, he and Glimmer rolled her onto her side, pillowing her head on Glimmer’s lap, hoping it would ease her breathing. Finally, she stopped making those horrible liquid noises, but when he placed his hand on her back, it was still. He reached to feel the pulse in Catra’s throat, knowing it was too late.

Tears filled his eyes; Catra’s death was going to devastate Adora. He only hoped grief wouldn’t cripple her in the fight against Horde Prime. And then he hated himself for being so selfish. He tried to think of something- anything- comforting to say but came up empty.

And then...well…he was not at all sure what happened. She-Ra walked over and knelt. “Come on, Catra,” she whispered. “You’re not done. Not yet.” Denial fought with despair in her voice as she held her childhood friend to her. A golden glow of healing magic wrapped itself around the two of them.

Too transfixed to move, Glimmer and Bow shared a “are you seeing this too?” look.

When the light cleared She Ra faded out. For a second, Catra didn’t move, and they all held their breath. Was it even possible for SHe Ra’s magic to heal someone this close to death?

Catra coughed. “Hey, Adora,” she said, her voice soft. She smiled. For a heartbeat, she looked genuinely content, but then some

memory seemed to fill in. The woman's eyes went wide, her face perplexed as she tried to understand where she was.

Adora pulled her up and into a hug. Catra was limp for a second, then she buried her head in Adora's shoulder, grabbing on so hard that her claws went through Adora's jacket. Bow would swear he heard Catra *purring* as they held onto each other for dear life.

After a few minutes, it became clear that the two weren't moving for a while. Bow tapped Glimmer's shoulder, and they both retreated across the bridge to where Entrapta and Wrong Hordak hung out by the console under the window.

"We should find somewhere private, so Catra can sleep." Bow said softly, remembering what it felt like when he had been on the receiving end of She Ra's speed-healing. "She's in rough shape. She needs somewhere she can feel safe."

"There's a brig on the ship," Entrapta volunteered. "Remember? It's full of boxes. You said we should use it as a storeroom."

"Well, we had no idea how long we would be out here." Bow protested. "I didn't think we'd be taking prisoners."

" *Is* she a prisoner?" asked Entrapta, fiddling with the end of her pigtail. She looked worried, but Bow couldn't tell why. Was she worried about Catra running around loose, or was she concerned about locking her up?

Glimmer looked over her shoulder at where Adora and Catra still clung to each other. "No. Whatever else she is, she's not our prisoner."

Entrapta relaxed, her face lighting up into her signature grin. "Oh, good!"

Bow considered. "I think the brig is a good idea, though. It's warm there."

"Plus, I think she'd like the privacy," Glimmer said.

“We can empty it pretty easily.” Entrapta brought her tracker pad out, checking her records. “It’s not anything heavy--just extra food and water that wouldn’t fit into the galley or the cargo hold. There’s room for it in the hold now.”

The four (Wrong Hordak was excited to help his “exalted brothers”) of them made quick work of the boxes, stacking them in the galley and the corridor.

Crouching beside Adora, Bow whispered that they’d set up a bed for Catra. She gave no sign she’d heard, but Adora nodded. “Hey, Catra?” she murmured. No response. Adora whispered a few more times, but the smaller woman stayed rigid.

“I’m going to carry you,” Adora warned. She staggered up to stand on shaking legs.

Worried by the tremors in Adora’s muscles, Bow moved forward. “Can I help?”

“I’ve got her!” snarled the blonde woman. Dropping back, she twitched Catra out of Bow’s reach. A seemingly involuntary defense, as if Adora wanted to shield Catra from anyone or anything.

He followed in case she might need help. Watching Adora limp down the hallway, Bow wondered what bones Adora had broken that She Ra speed-healed and if he could convince her to rest rather than push through the pain.

That night, Adora never made it back to the bunk room. He was pretty sure she slept outside Catra’s door.

Only Adora and Entrapta saw Catra again until after She Ra took care of Prime’s bots. After the battle, Entrapta chirped happily about removing Catra’s chip as she worked on Darla from the bridge, thrilled at being able to tell someone about it now that they weren’t in danger of being blown to pieces. Bow sat limply in the captain’s chair, catching his breath, letting her excited chatter wash over him.

Adora stumbled onto the bridge, face pale with exhaustion. Groaning, she lay down on the floor with her arms spread. It looked so comfortable that Bow and then Entrapta joined her until Glimmer came in with dinner.

The smell of food probably brought Catra out of hiding- the galley was on the same floor as all the sleeping rooms. Hesitating on the threshold of the open door, Hordak's former second-in-command and bane of their existence stood for a minute, momentarily frozen by the glare of their combined attention. Impossibly small, she wore nothing but a pair of shorts and a sports bra. Her fur hid the prominence of her ribs, but Bow remembered how she'd felt as he'd carried her--far too light and nothing but bone under her pelt.

As if by reflex, she sank to one knee, then she seemed to realize where she was and awkwardly curled up to sit just outside their circle, not speaking, gazing hungrily at them. He and Glimmer scooted apart to give her a place to sit. Her ears came forward in surprise, and she looked at Adora.

Something unspoken passed between the two of them, and Adora smiled at her. Shyly, Catra came forward and took a steamed bun from Glimmer.

As Catra ate, she relaxed enough to tease Adora, who grumbled back at her. Then, something happened (Bow could not figure out what), and pain sparked in Catra's eyes. Wordlessly, she stood and walked out.

"Just give her some space." Glimmer put a hand on Adora's arm, preventing her from following. "She's been through a lot, and she needs some time to process."

Adora nodded, sitting back on the floor. "Yeah, okay." She didn't even pretend to pay attention to the conversation after that.

That night (okay, the time when they decided it was night and they put Darla on autopilot, dimmed the lights, and went to

sleep), Adora and Catra came to some kind of understanding because Adora stayed with her (Bow hoped they'd shared the bed rather than Adora sleeping on the floor again). Entrapta had already claimed one of the other rooms near the engines and taken Wrong Hordak with her, leaving the bunkroom for him and Glimmer.

The next morning, he slept late, as did Glimmer. They didn't see either Adora or Catra for breakfast, but they were probably exhausted and trying to catch up on sleep. A couple of times, Bow quietly knocked on their door to see if they needed anything; they didn't answer. Around lunchtime, he ran into Adora as she walked to the bathroom in her underwear (Bow had long since gotten used to the fact that Adora had almost zero body modesty), a towel slung over her shoulder.

"Everything going okay?" he asked.

Adora smiled brightly, looking better than she had for a long time. "Yeah. She's okay. She's just catching up on sleep." Her smile dimmed a little, and she looked back down the hall towards their room. "You know how the whole healing thing works. And she was pretty banged up."

"Yeah." Bow nodded, then crossed his arms and leaned against the wall. "What about you?"

"Me?" Adora's gaze darted around the corridor, her smile becoming nervous, then falling away. "I'm fine?"

"Uh-huh." He raised an eyebrow. "Really?

Adora hunched her shoulders, and her cheeks turned pink. "I-I guess I'm a little tired too." She straightened, suddenly anxious. "Why? Did you guys need me or something? Oh, gosh, I'm sorry. I wasn't trying to duck out of things. You should have woke me up. I can come help with…."

Bow suppressed an eye roll and shook his head. "Adora, it's fine," he said gently. "I'm glad you're getting the rest you need." He

gestured towards her. “You were pretty banged up, too.”

“I don’t want to talk about it,” Adora said softly, her eyes pleading.

“Okay," Bow said. That was really all he needed for her to say to know it had been bad. He was probably the only one (other than Catra now) who understood how truly shitty the speed-healing thing felt. “When you do, you know where I am.”

She smiled, looking relieved, gave him a quick hug, and headed down the hall.

As he watched her walk away, he saw a profound change in her appearance. The scars on her back that Catra gave her at the Battle of Bright Moon were gone, replaced with a different set. He wondered if she knew. Now was not the time to ask, but he made a mental note to bring it up later.

Later, Glimmer knocked on their door to ask them if they wanted dinner. Adora’s snores were the only response.

That night, he woke up hungry. On the next cot over, Glimmer breathed softly. They didn’t really want to be apart, so they shoved two cots together. The bunk room seemed to support several different configurations of sleeping arrangements. A series of shelf-like metal bunks bolted to the wall were folded up and out of the way in favor of the cots they found in a storage locker.

Carefully, he slid out of bed and padded out of the bunkroom without bothering to put on a light.

The overhead light was already on in the galley when the door slid open and the newest member of their crew knelt on the counter, digging through one of the food storage cupboards. Catra looked to see who was coming in. The expression on her face turned wary. He supposed he could not blame her; they had never had an interaction except as enemies.

“Hey,” he said, smiling at her as he came in and brushed past.

“Hey,” she returned the greeting but not the smile. “I was hungry.” Her voice was defensive. “I’ll…uh…just get out of your way….” She waved a box of dehydrated protein slaw as if to illustrate that she was done here.

“It’s fine,” he said. “You’re not in my way. I was hungry too. I was thinking about making something.” He wasn’t, but if he started cooking, he might get Catra to have a conversation. When Adora talked about her, she always seemed to cut herself off before the subject got too personal. The only thing he really knew was that they’d grown up together and that Adora would sometimes startle from sleep, calling out to her. Oh, and Catra had pretty sharp teeth. “I can make you something too if you want.”

Still wary, Catra nodded, hopping off the counter (taking her box of space rations with her) so he could get into the cupboards.

“What do you like?”

“Whatever.” She shrugged and sat down on the bench next to the table. “I mean… whatever you want to make is fine. I’m not exactly picky.” She threw some of the crunchy slaw into her mouth.

“Eggs?” he asked. “We’ve got some in the cold storage, and I make a pretty good omelet.” Without looking at her, he pulled out the pan and ingredients.

“Eggs? Like from birds or lizards?”

“Chicken eggs. Is that okay ?” He wondered if she was queasy about eating animal products if she’d only ever eaten rations before.

Surprising him, she nodded. “Yeah, I like eggs."

The whole time Bow cooked, Catra said nothing, but he heard her munching her way through the box, and felt her eyes on him. He had to pay attention to his cooking, so he couldn’t see what her

face was doing. He asked her to get plates and cutlery, mostly to see if she would talk if he distracted her.

Nothing.

He sat down, putting the omelet in front of her. “Thanks,” she grunted but didn’t touch her fork until he started to eat.

“So…” the archer said after a few bites, unable to stand the quiet. “How are you feeling?”

“Fine,” she said around the eggs she shoved into her mouth like a starving woman.

A starving woman.

The thought hit him like a physical blow when he remembered the feel of Catra’s spine under his hand. He shut his mouth; conversations would wait until Catra was less fragile physically. He was glad he suggested an omelet; they were easier on the stomach than a lot of the things they had on hand, but maybe he should do a discreet search of Darla’s database to see if she had information on the best things to feed someone who had not eaten properly for…he counted it up in his head…much too long?

One of Catra’s ears twitched, and her head shot up. Both of her ears swiveled as if trying to locate the source of a sound. “Where’s Sparkles?” she growled, staring at the door.

“Sleeping, why?”

Catra’s head snapped back around so she could glare at him. “She's alone?” Her fork fell to the floor with a clatter as she jumped up and tore from the room.

Bow followed, but she was so fast. He had no chance of catching up, no idea what had gotten her so upset or where she was going. Fortunately, she stayed on the same level as the galley and raced down the central corridor, the lights flickering on as she passed. He almost caught up with her near the engine room.

Skidding to a stop, she banged her fist against the button to open the door of the room she shared with Adora.

“Adora!” she hissed. “Get up! Now!” Then she continued on down the corridor.

Adora hurried out of the door, nearly running into Bow. “What’s going..?” she started to ask.

The lithe woman turned left at the end of the corridor towards the bunkroom. They heard the door slide open, and the sound of Glimmer’s wailing sobs filled the air. They stared at each other, horrified to realize that neither of them had been able to hear their friend’s distress.

“Sparkles!” Catra barked. “I’m here. It’s fine.”

“C-Catra!’ Glimmer gasped, her voice raw and hoarse. “I woke up, and no one was here. I couldn't see,” she sobbed. "I called for the lights, and it didn’t work… I-I-I thought I was back there."

“Yeah. I know.” That raspy voice became soft, more gentle than Bow had ever heard it. “But, we’re here now. We’re safe.”

Bow stared into Adora’s shocked eyes before she shook herself and grabbed his hand, dragging him along. She dropped his hand as they reached the door but didn’t immediately go in. Instead, she made a little “wait-a-second” gesture and peeked around the doorway. Bow followed suit, leaning over her to take a look before they went in.

Catra had her hands on Glimmer's shoulders while her tail stroked the side of her face. The action seemed incongruously sweet--almost *cute* if such a word could be applied to Hordak's Second.

“It’s okay,” she said again with a gentle rumble (she really *was* purring). “It was just a dream.”

“Hey, what happened?” Adora asked softly.

Glimmer threw herself into Adora's arms with an inarticulate cry when the blonde sat next to her.

"Bad dream," Catra supplied with an attempt at a casual shrug. A significant look passed between the two over Glimmer's head.

Catra edged away, then stood, her expression closed, her purring stopped. She turned to leave, but before she did, she grabbed Bow by the upper arm, holding tightly so that he felt the points of her claws dig into his biceps.

"Don't. Leave. Her. Alone," she growled into his ear, her mouth so close he felt her breath. "Not even for a minute."

Bow nodded slightly, and Catra let go of his arm. He settled down next to his distraught friend, in the place the dark-haired woman had occupied, adding his embrace to Adora's.

Catra paused at the door to give the three of them that same hungry look she had at dinner time the other day, then she was gone.

It took a long time for Glimmer to calm down. "I'm sorry I freaked out," Glimmer said, sounding mortified when her tears ran their course.

"Hey. It's okay. We all get nightmares sometimes." Adora said.

Glimmer shook her head. "I wasn't asleep." She blew out her breath in a long sigh.

"Do you want to talk about it?" Bow asked.

"Not…not yet." She attempted a brave smile. "I'm sort of hungry, I think. What time is it?"

"Breakfast time, I guess." Bow grinned at his friends, happy to be able to offer an easy distraction.

By the time the three of them made their way back to the galley, Catra was nowhere in sight, and the mess was cleaned up. The raw ingredients for three omelets sat in the clean frying pan next to a stack of clean plates. She seemed to have finished off Bow's plate as well as her own. That made sense. The prepared omelets wouldn’t keep well, and she probably couldn't bear to see them wasted.

Adora’s expression turned wistful when they came into the empty galley.

“Catra’s still really tired, huh?” Bow asked her cautiously.

“Yeah. She probably went back to bed," Adora agreed, sitting down next to Glimmer. She chewed her bottom lip and glanced behind her towards their room."All she wants to do is eat and sleep."

Bow wanted to ask Adora more, but knowing how good Catra’s hearing was, he hesitated to say anything without knowing where she was. Instead, he stuck to safe subjects for the rest of breakfast.

After she finished eating, Adora started picking up the plates. She almost always cleaned up because she couldn't cook, and she couldn't sit still once she was done anyway. Glimmer swallowed her last bite and stood to help. Fortunately, Darla had an automatic dishwasher, so cleanup didn't take long.

Entrapta popped her head in. "Hi, Glimmer!” she warbled, “I fixed the lights and the door in your room. The voice commands work in there now, so Darla will respond if you call her name." She didn't wait for a reply, she just kept going.

"Oh, thanks." Confused, Glimmer looked at Bow and Adora. They both shrugged. "How did you know the lights needed fixing?" Glimmer called out.

"Huh? Oh, Catra let me know," Entrapta called back. "You're welcome!"

“Huh.” Bow scratched his head as the three of them exchanged bemused glances.

Apparently feeling better, Catra prowled around the ship all morning. Bow saw her on the bridge a few times but didn’t stop for conversation. She’d come in the door for just a second, not say anything and then leave. It was a little unnerving.

Around lunchtime, he went down to the galley to see what he could find to eat. Glimmer and Adora were on the bridge, keeping an eye on Darla’s course while Adora continued to fill Glimmer in on the events on Etheria. Entrapta and Wrong Hordak were *under* the bridge, working directly beneath the floorplates, repairing something deep in the tangled wires.

As he dug through the cold storage to see what was there, a soft cough let him know Catra was behind him. He turned with a smile. “Hey. How's it going? Are you hungry?”

Catra stood in the doorway, her face uncertain. She swallowed audibly. “Yes.” The word was offered as a confession. Standing with one arm wrapped defensively around her, her eyes narrowed. She started to take a step back.

Before she could retreat, Bow said, "I'm just trying to decide what to make. What do you like?"

"As long as it's not 'nutritional amniotic fluid, I really don't care," she rasped.

He shuddered. “Ew. Yeah, we're not eating that, I promise." He was rewarded with a sardonic little half-smile.

Cautiously, she stepped into the galley, "Do you… uh… need any help?" She looked around. "I can't cook, but if you tell me what to do, I can chop things up or whatever. I'm pretty good with a knife."

"Sure! That'd be great!" Bow said. “Look at this. I found some bread.” He held up the prize that he’d just defrosted. “We can

make sandwiches. Those are easy."

"I'll take your word for it." That same little half-smile quirked her mouth. A pause, then she rolled her eyes and said, "I have no idea what those are."

Oh, right. Just like Adora.

He grabbed the bread loaf and some meat and cheese, handing the items to Catra one at a time. Because Entrapta didn't care for meat, he grabbed the peanut butter and jelly as well. "You put whatever you like between two slices of bread. That's a sandwich."

She nodded. "Are we making this for everyone?"

"Yeah. I usually make the food. Mostly because I like to and…."

"And because Adora would burn the place down, Entrapta would be so distracted tinkering with the gadgets in the galley she'd let everyone starve, and Sparkles only knows how to cook like three things."

Bow laughed. "Yeah, pretty much." He put some sliced meat and cheese down on the counter. "You'll probably like ham and cheese." Darla's database was very informative this morning. She said that Catra was a magicat, that they required more protein on average than most other Etherians, and it was best if it came from animal products—something about microbiomes and enzymes that was way over his head.

"What's this stuff?" Opening the jar of peanut butter, the dark-haired woman sniffed dubiously.

"Peanut butter. Entrapta and Adora like it. Use a knife to spread it on one slice of bread." He slid over the jar of jelly. "Put that on another. And then put them together so that the peanut butter and jelly are in the middle. Tell you what, you make two of those, and I'll make the meat sandwiches."

“Okay, got it.” With quick fingers, she made two sandwiches. She watched Bow slice the ones he made in half and set them on separate plates. She followed suit with the first one she finished. The other she put on a second plate, seemed to contemplate it for a second, then she quartered it.

“You’re holding out on me,” Bow said, grinning. “You know a lot more than you’re letting on.”

Wrong tactic. Catra hissed at him, and the hand that held the knife came up like she thought she might need to defend herself. “What’s that supposed to mean?” she gritted. Because she was still only wearing shorts and a sports bra, he could see that all the hair on her spine stood up.

Bow had no idea what might have triggered that, so he moved over a half step to give her some room, and then he said, as cheerfully as he could, “Oh, it’s just that you are clearly at expert level sandwich-making. The only thing you didn’t do was slice off the crusts.”

The panic faded from her eyes, replaced with a flicker of humor. “I told you, I’m good with sharp things.” She looked down at the sandwiches on the counter. “What part is the crust?”

“The brown part." He pointed. “The white part is the crumb.”

“Like this?” Deftly, she sliced the crusts off both sandwiches. Bow didn’t miss that she popped them into her mouth rather than throwing them out.

“Perfect.” He finished the three sandwiches he was making. He eyed the too-thin woman surreptitiously and then decided that being direct would probably piss her off. Instead of asking her if she wanted a second sandwich, he resorted to a little subterfuge. “Oh, shoot. I wonder if Wrong Hordak wants peanut butter or ham and cheese?" He shrugged. "I guess I'll make both. If he doesn’t eat them, you know someone else will.”

Catra didn't reply. She cut the quartered sandwich twice more so that it was in eight pieces. She glanced up and saw him looking at her. Her cheeks turned a little pink. “What? It’s for Entrapta, isn’t it?” She didn’t wait for him to reply; instead, she put the plates on a tray to take to the bridge.

Deciding not to press her, Bow followed with a second tray full of drinks he poured from the cold storage.

When they got there, Catra put the tray she carried down on the floor where they’d eaten the night before. She didn’t make a move towards it and looked at Bow and then Adora as if she wasn't sure what to do next. It seemed that Catra was reluctant to take any food that was not expressly offered to her, so Bow made sure he handed off her plate before he passed Adora, Glimmer, and Entrapta theirs.

“Thanks,” she muttered and looked away as she took it.

“Tiny triangles!” squealed Entrapta. “Thank you, Bow!”

"You should thank Catra, " Bow tilted his head towards the woman.

Entrapta turned on her thousand-watt smile. “Thank you, Catra!”

“Yeah, whatever. Don’t make a big deal.” Hunching her shoulders, Catra took a bite of her sandwich.

Adora came to sit down next to Catra once she got her plate, grinning. “Tiny triangles?” she asked quietly and bumped Catra’s shoulder with her own.

"What? I'm good with knives." Rolling her eyes, Catra bumped Adora’s shoulder back. “Idiot.”

“Brat.”

They both giggled like a pair of kids.

Bow did a double-take; he couldn't help it. He was hard-pressed to remember the last time Adora laughed (in a good way, at least). He thought maybe it was before Glimmer became queen.

Catra noticed him looking and immediately stopped, scowling at him and hunching her shoulders again.

A crease formed between Adora’s eyebrows at the change in the other woman's demeanor, and she followed Catra’s line of sight. Apologetically, the blonde smiled at him.

Neither of them spoke again while they ate, but Bow noticed Adora’s free hand gently pet down Catra’s arm. Just once, it seemed as though Adora wasn't sure Catra would be okay with it.

When they were finished, Wrong Hordak hadn't touched the extra ham and cheese sandwich. The archer didn't miss how Catra's eyes kept straying to it.

He poked Glimmer. She met his eyes, and he indicated Catra with a nod of his chin, then he directed his gaze at the last sandwich.

Glimmer understood. "Hey, Catra? You want the last sandwich?"

Suspicion kindled in Catra's eyes; she glanced at Adora.

Adora smiled at her. "You should take it. I'm not a huge fan of ham and cheese."

For some reason, Catra's cheeks reddened as she muttered, "Yeah, that would be great." She reached over to grab it quickly. "Thanks."

The second sandwich went down as quickly as the first. Then she started cleaning up their empty plates without comment. Adora stood to help, but Catra just muttered, “I got it.” She stacked the trays and then the dirty dishware, taking them off of the bridge. She didn’t return.

At dinnertime, when Bow went down to try and figure out what to make, Catra was already sitting at one of the benches, apparently waiting to help.

“What should I do?” The woman sounded like she was waiting for a mission briefing. Abruptly, he remembered how it had taken Adora months to lose that tone. It wasn’t just a general Horde thing because Scorpia didn’t sound like that.

“Could you chop these up?” He pushed the vegetables he’d pulled out of cold storage towards her.

A curt nod. “How small do you want them? Or does it matter?”

“About so big.” He held up his fingers about two inches apart. “I’ll just make a stir fry.”

As before, she was quiet, but he felt her eyes on him as if she was taking mental notes on everything he did.

When it was almost done, Bow asked, “Catra? Could you call the others and tell them dinner’s ready? I don’t feel like carting it to the bridge."

Wiping her hands on a towel, Catra nodded, walked to a panel on the wall next to the door that Bow had never even looked at, and pressed a button. “Hey, um, crew? Dinner’s ready in the galley.”

Bow heard the words reverberate around the hallway. She’d hit the PA system. He didn’t even know Darla had that. “How did you know what that button did? Can you read First One’s writing too?”

“Huh?” Catra gave him a narrow-eyed stare. “No. It's obvious, isn’t it?”

“Uh, no?”

Catra’s eyes narrowed further, and her tail lashed. Maybe she thought he was making fun of her? For a moment, he thought she was going to storm out. Then she seemed to change her mind-

Bow could see her chewing on the inside of her cheek. Her mouth hardened, not with anger but with determination. Taking a deep breath as if to steel herself, she pointed to a tiny grill set in a round panel next to a line of four buttons. “This is a speaker, see?”

She looked back at him and searched his face. He didn’t know what she wanted, so he tried to show interest. “How do you know?”

“It’s about eye level, so that means it’s also about ear level. If you look past the mesh, you can see the speaker. It looks like the ones we use in the Horde. Maybe there are only so many ways to make a speaker or something. I don’t know.” She shrugged.

About a palm width beneath the speaker was another little metal plate with small round holes in a circular pattern set into it. She pointed to it. “That makes this the mic. That’s mouth level.”

“And the buttons?”

“Most of the time, the biggest one is the Public Address. Or it's set apart. Because that’s the one you might need fast. They’re usually a different color than the others too.” She pointed to the large red one. “Although, I bet if you asked Darla to call people, she’d do it.”

“Yeah, I just thought of that.” Bow said sheepishly. “But then why have that set up at all?” He nodded at the panel.

“I don’t know. But have you noticed that just about everything Darla does also has a physical switch? Obviously, there’s some kind of advantage,” Catra said.

“Oh, wow.” Bow was honestly impressed. No wonder Entrapta and Catra got along. No wonder Catra was able to learn enough about Prime’s systems to send Glimmer to them. “That’s really smart thinking.”

That earned him another of Catra’s narrow-eyed, tail-lashing looks, but then she seemed to realize he meant it. Her cheeks turned pink, and she returned to the sink, hastily returning to her task. “Yeah, okay,” she muttered, looking uncomfortable.

The rest of the crew bustled in, and the conversation moved on. Once again, Catra spoke mostly to Adora.

Bow made sure that Catra’s plate of stir fry had what would have been Entrapta’s portion of meat and gave Entrapta almost all Catra's vegetables (both of them would probably have eaten whatever they were served, but Lance had taught him better than to set himself up for failure by serving what he knew his guests wouldn’t like). After the first bite, he was gratified to watch Cara’s ears go up in surprise and then eat the rest with an almost Adora-like gusto.

After dinner, Entrapta and Wrong Hordak went back to the bridge. Glimmer and Adora started to clean up. Catra jumped up to help, but Glimmer put her hand out to stop her. “No, it's okay. You cooked. And Entrapta’s been working on the repairs all day. We’ll get this.”

“Oh. Okay,” After a second of uncertain hovering, she shook her head and squared her shoulders, leaving without a word.

Adora sighed and looked a little mournful.

"How is she?" Glimmer asked.

Adora put her finger over her lips. She poked her head outside the door, looked both ways, and then shut it. "She's okay. I think?”

The last dirty plate went into the dishwasher, and the three of them sat down at the table.

“She says she’s not used to all this togetherness.” Adora’s face sagged, and she bit her lip. “She seems… I don’t know… “ She turned her head to stare at the door.

Glimmer sighed and gave Bow an unreadable glance before putting her hand on Adora's. "It's going to take her some time to recover."

"I guess." Adora's eyes stayed on the door.

"But..?" Bow supplied, hearing the unspoken caveat.

"She's jumpy, even for Catra. And she's having more trouble sleeping than usual. That's all."

Glimmer nodded. "She's been through a lot."

"Has she talked about any of it yet?" Bow asked.

That got a little chuckle from the blonde woman. "No. Catra's never been real big on talking about her feelings." Adora's smile was soft and concerned. "She's been trying, though. Trying to be a little…I don't know…."

"Less mean?" Glimmer put in with a grin.

Adora nodded, her smile becoming wry.

Knowing it was pretty hopeless (Catra wasn't the only one who had trouble talking about feelings), Bow tried to get Adora to open up. "So, how are you doing?"

"Me? I'm fine. I mean, She Ra's back, right?" As if that was the only thing that mattered. "We have a chance to defeat Prime now."

That was not what he meant, but he was not sure Adora ever understood that; her entire self-worth was wrapped up in her *usefulness* .

He remembered what he wanted to ask her. "Speaking of She Ra, did you know the scars on your back changed? The ones Ca… the ones you got at Brightmoon?"

"What?" Adora put her hand under her shirt to feel her lower back. Her eyes went wide when she felt the smooth skin. Jumping up, she pulled off her belt and jacket, putting them down on the bench next to her so she could feel more of her back with her hand. She pulled up her shirt and showed her back to Glimmer.

"Oh, wow." Glimmer affirmed. "They *have* changed. I mean, they're not even in the same place."

Since the Battle of Brightmoon, Adora had eight long vertical scars on her back, from just below her shoulder blades to her waist. They had taken a long time to heal over, and no matter how often Adora became She Ra, those marks never disappeared. When Glimmer and Adora were fighting, they became painful, opening up and looking almost infected. Bow only knew about that part because he was Adora's go-to for any kind of medical advice since she always flatly refused to see an actual healer. After Adora broke the sword, they went back to being fine raised lines.

He never understood why She Ra's healing magic didn't erase them. Only one book in his dads' library had any real insight; it had said that things like scars, tattoos, or piercings might be kept if She Ra's host (that was how the book described it) truly desired it. That didn't seem right because Adora had always been curiously self-conscious about them.

Yesterday, however, Bow saw that those old scars were gone, the skin where they had been smooth and unmarred. Just above her bra strap, Adora sported eight brand-new scars on her shoulder blades. These were not angry or fresh; rather, the short raised parallel lines that ended in white crescents seemed old and long-healed.

Unable to feel them, Adora pulled her shirt off, stripped down to her bra, and tried to see her reflection in the shiny metal of the cupboard doors.

The shiny metal in the galley distorted her reflection too much for Adora to make out the marks. "I need to find a mirror." She

snagged her shirt and jacket from the bench and closed the door behind her.

“That was weird,” Glimmer said after a moment. “But, no weirder than usual, I guess. I didn’t get a chance to ask you how is Adora with all this? I tried to ask her, but you know how she is. She told me about Light Hope and breaking the Sword.

Bow sighed, wondering if it would ever get easier to talk about Glimmer’s lack of judgment with the Heart of Etheria. He hoped so. Right now, he preferred to talk about anything else, but she had asked. He just hoped it wouldn’t send Glimmer into a guilt spiral. “Can I just say that I’m really glad She Ra came back? And not because of the war. Losing her…” He shook his head and met Glimmer’s eyes. “I was really afraid we were going to lose Adora too.”

“What do you mean?”

For the next hour, Bow explained Adora’s increasingly reckless behavior after Glimmer’s disappearance. How Adora’s inability to sleep and her headaches culminated in a collapse from exhaustion.

Throughout, Glimmer listened with building distress. “When she told me about breaking the Sword, she left all of that out.”

“Yeah.” Bow replied, not at all surprised. “And it didn’t help that Shadow Weaver kept needling her about it until your dad stopped it. I heard them arguing. He was really mad. It was kind of scary, actually.”

Glimmer winced. “I’m glad my dad and Aunt Casta know how to handle Shadow Weaver.”

“Yeah.” Bow nodded, thinking of some of the things he overheard. “Your dad wouldn’t talk about it, though. ”

“Yeah. Aunt Casta and my mom never wanted to talk about it, either.” Sighing, Glimmer looked down at the table. With one

hand, she traced curly patterns that, if there was any magic available, would become sigils. "I wish they had. I might not have listened to her. "

“Can I ask you something?” Bow said, changing the subject, not wanting to get back into how he and Adora told Glimmer that listening to Shadow Weaver was a terrible idea.

“Sure.” She seemed to welcome the change too.

“Catra…she told me I shouldn’t leave you alone.”

“She told you that?”

“Yeah. When you woke up so upset, she told me not to leave you alone. How come?” They hadn’t actually talked about what happened on Prime’s ship.

A long time passed and Glimmer didn’t say anything; she just kept tracing those patterns, her frown deepening. Fear, anger, then raw disgust flashed across her visage as she cringed away from her own thoughts. She wouldn’t meet his eyes. Bow kept his mouth shut to give her time to find the words.

"After I was captured,” she finally said in a voice barely louder than a breath, “He didn’t actually do much to me. He just… left me alone.” Glimmer winced and then said, “Mostly anyway.”

“The whole time he had you? That was…” Bow hesitated, trying to count the time since Glimmer was taken in his head. “That was a long time.”

“Catra came to talk to me. Prime told her to stay away, but she came anyway. Sometimes, she’d stay for a couple of hours." The young sorceress flattened her hand on the table and made a sweeping motion that Bow knew was supposed to collect magic. One day when he’d been waiting for Glimmer to get done talking to Shadow Weaver, he’d eavesdropped on what turned out to be a magic lesson. The gesture was meant to return unused magic to the sorcerer rather than disperse it.

Glimmer saw Bow looking. “What?” she asked quietly. “It doesn’t hurt to see if any magic is floating around, does it?”

He rested his hand on hers, gratified when she wrapped her fingers around his.

“Do you remember how upset Adora used to get when my mom grounded me?” Her voice was low, and she leaned in a little closer. “I think that understand it better from some of the things Catra said.” Glimmer huffed a bitter little laugh. “I honestly think Catra was trying to make me feel better.” She paused, tilting her head thoughtfully. “It sort of worked. I got so caught up in talking to her that I was okay for a while.”

"But then….?”

"Then, Prime would send for me." She shuddered and wrapped her arms around herself as if at a sudden chill.

"What happened then?"

She closed her eyes and shook her head.

Bow reached out to put his hand on her shoulder.

A squeak came from her throat. Her eyes popped open, and her arm shot up between them as if to fend him off. Her hand shook as she lowered her arm.

"Glimmer?"

"Sorry. It's just…." She took a deep breath. "I… I guess it's going to take me a while to adjust, too.

"It's okay. " Mentally, Bow added *sudden contact* to the growing list of things that Glimmer was edgy about. "Can I give you a hug?" He almost never asked her that because she was usually as touchy-feely as him.

Tears threatened to fall from Glimmer's eyes, but she nodded and opened her arms. For a while they just held each other.

Eventually, they made their way to the bridge again. Entrapta and Wrong Hordak had replaced most of the floor plating they pulled up. Catra was sitting on the floor talking to Entrapta who fiddled with some wires in the last opening.

"Okay, yeah. So that means..?" Catra was asking. She gave them a little wave of acknowledgment when they came in. Adora was off on the other side of the captain’s chair, practicing with her staff.

"Well, it means that … " Entrapta stopped, apparently looking for something. "Hey, can you hand me the long-handled widget puller?" She held multiple tools with her pigtails already.

"Sure." Catra looked around at the assortment scattered on the floor. "Uhh, which one is it?"

Entrapta glanced over. "The black one with the yellow stripe. Behind you."

Adora abruptly stopped her exercises and looked over at Catra and Entrapta.

Catra turned around, hesitated, then picked up a tool with a red handle and an orange stripe. "This one?"

"Yep!" Entrapta caught the tool Catra tossed. "Oh, and I need the short-handled gadget gripper. That's the blue one with the black rings."

Again, Catra hesitated. She picked up a purple-handled tool with red rings. "This?" She held it out as if it was a snake that might bite.

Entrapta nodded her head happily. "Yep. Thanks!"

Catra was about to toss it to Entrapta when Glimmer gave voice to the same thing Bow was thinking. "That's not blue, it's purple."

The tech Princess shrugged off-handedly. "Oh, I know it looks like that to you and me. But Catra can't see red well, so that looks blue to her."

Catra sucked in a sharp breath, her ears flattened against her head, eyes suspiciously bright. Then her eyes narrowed, and the pain in her face turned to fury. She jumped up, turning to face Adora, her fists clenched. "You TOLD her?"

At the same moment, Adora whipped her head around to look at Catra and gasped, "You told HER?!"

The two closed the distance between them, and they began yelling into each other's face, hurt and anger echoing off the metal walls as they argued. Bow hardly caught a word.

 "Of course, I didn't!"

“Then how does she know?”

"Because you must have told her!

“I did not!"

"How could you?"

"Why would I?"

"I can't believe you!"

The two seemed likely to come to blows judging by how they clenched their fists and shouted into each other’s faces. The only thing Bow could think to do was really, really stupid; he interposed himself between the women. "Hey, hey! Time out, you two!" He'd seen his dads do this when his brothers fought, and he didn't *think* Catra was likely to kill him for it.

Adora ceased and fell back immediately. Tears filled her eyes as she turned away. "I did not. I never would," she asserted quietly, wrapping her arms around herself.

Though her hackles were up, her teeth bared, and claws out, Catra stepped back too. She kept her voice low as she spoke to Adora's stiff back, gesturing at Entrapta. "If you didn't tell her, who did?"

"Tell me what?" Befuddled, Entrapta pushed her mask up to stare at the spectacle.

"That I can't… " Catra stopped and wrapped her arms around herself, taking almost the same pose as Adora. The set of her mouth made Bow think she was fighting back tears.

"Catra doesn't… she can't…." Adora turned around to look at Catra apologetically. "She can't see… as well as we do. I mean, she can't…."

"What Entrapta said." The dark-haired woman stared at her bare feet as she quietly confessed with the air of admitting something shameful.

"Oh." Entrapta fiddled with one of her pigtails, as she always did when people's emotions confused her. "Well, nobody *told* me. Almost all magicats have trouble seeing red." She looked around at the others. "I…I thought everyone knew."

In lockstep with each other, Adora and Catra stared at each other with their mouths open for a beat."What?" they cried in stereo.

Entrapta nodded. "Well, yeah." She tilted her head quizzically, her gaze switching between the two women. "I mean, at least that's what the data I have on them says."

"Explain," Catra demanded when it didn't seem like Entrapta would say anything else.

Entrapta focused on Catra. "Well, magicats generally have protanopia since their eyes are adapted to lower light. They are still considered trichromats but have far fewer cone cells for color perception, which causes…"

"Stop!" Catra shouted. She clenched her teeth together and took a deep breath through her nose. When she spoke again, her voice was a quiet, tightly controlled growl. "What. Does. That. Mean?

"Oh." Entrapta took a second, as she often did when she wanted to break down complex ideas. "The cells in the eye that see color need more light to work. You have more of the other kind. The ones that need less light. "

"Wait. What?"

Entrapta shrugged. "Magicats can see shades of blue and green, but reds and pinks are confusing. They may appear more green, while purple can look like another shade of blue. Lenses boosting the intensity of the light frequencies can create vision closely resembling our color perception by stimulating the retinal cells more strongly, but it…."

"Stop! Stop." This time Glimmer interrupted before Entrapta could lose them completely. "So…you're saying that people like Catra are *usually* colorblind?" she asked slowly.

Entrapta nodded. "Yes. Well, I wouldn't call it that in a magicat. It *is* normal for her people. It would be like calling us ultraviolet blind because we don't see in the same spectrum as someone like Scorpia."

Adora and Catra wore identical looks of shock as they stared at each other.

"Didn't anyone ever tell you that?" Glimmer asked Catra, her voice carefully neutral.

Catra shook her head and crossed her arms, turning away and scowling.

Adora moved closer to the other woman and put a hand on her shoulder. "We never mentioned it to anyone. Because well…"

"I didn't need to give Shadow Weaver any more reason to think I was defective," Catra growled. She made a jerky little motion as if to push Adora's hand off but seemed to change her mind in the middle and ran her hand through her hair instead.

"But, it's not a defect," Entrapta asserted, her face clearing. "It's an adaptation. The differences in your retina is part of the reason you see much better in the dark, and you're so attuned to movement."

"How does that work?" Bow asked curiously.

"Unlike people with our types of eyes." Entrapta indicated Bow, Adora, Glimmer, and herself. "Magicats have a reflective layer in the back of their eyes that give the cells another chance to fire. That's why her eyes shine in the dark, but ours don't."

"How much better?" Bow asked curiously.

"Oh, my gosh, a lot. Darla!" Entrapta called out. "Turn bridge lights down to minimum Entrapta-vision."

The room was plunged into darkness as even the windows darkened to block out the starlight. Glimmer gasped, and her hand grabbed Bow's in a death grip.

"So, what's your point?" Catra asked, her blue and yellow eyes shining clearly in what seemed total darkness.

"C-can you actually see in this?" Glimmer asked, her voice shaking.

"Uh, yeah," Catra snapped as if she thought the question was stupid. "What? Are you trying to tell me you can't?"

"Not well." In the few seconds, Bow's eyes adjusted to the point where he could see it wasn't completely dark, but he could make

out no details.

Entrapta shoved her mask into Bow’s hand. "Here! Put this on!"

Gingerly, Bow took the welding mask and put it over his face, and the bridge lit up nearly as bright as daylight but in varied shades of grey. "Oh, wow."

"What?" Catra stood with her arms folded, her expression was skeptical, as if she thought they were making fun of her. "What's the big deal?"

"It's fucking dark in here, Catra, " Glimmer said, sounding so angry she was near tears. Bow had never heard her be afraid of the dark before.

"Here." He took off the welding mask and passed it to her. “You can see through these.

"Oh. Oh, wow." Astonishment washed the fear from her voice.

"Can I try?" Adora asked timidly.

"Do you have more goggles?" Bow put in quickly, not wanting Glimmer to lose her ability to see.

"Yep. Hang on."

Bow heard the sounds of Entrapta rummaging around, and then Adora exclaimed, "Catra! I knew you saw better in the dark, but this is a lot more than I thought!"

Luminous yellow and blue irises, pupils round and reflecting, came to stand right in front of Bow. Something passed in front of his face between himself and her eyes. “You really can’t see?” She must have waved a hand in his face to see if he’d flinch.

"Here, Catra!" Entrapta chirped, gleeful to be able to share a discovery. "Try these. I set them to Entrapta-vision!"

"You are fucking with me," Catra growled after a moment.

“I don’t understand.” Entrapta sounded puzzled. “Why would I want to do that?”

"No way are all of you this blind. How could you even function?"

"Catra, we're not kidding," Adora murmured. "Remember that time I twisted my ankle? And all those times I tripped over things?"

"Darla. Set lights to normal. " Catra barked.

Everyone made a noise of pain and surprise at the light dazzle. The door slid shut behind a fleeing Catra.

"I'll… uh… go see if she's okay. " Adora hurried after her.

The pair didn’t make a reappearance, and eventually, Glimmer and Bow headed down to their room

As they walked, Glimmer seemed to have something on her mind. She cleared her throat a few times before she seemed to work up the nerve. “Um… Bow?” Glimmer’s voice was soft, and she sounded nervous. “I… Could I ask you to do me a favor?” She stopped walking and faced him.

“Of course.” Bow took her hands in his and gave them a squeeze. "What do you need?"

She looked down at their joined hands rather than him. “I *need* a shower.”

Glimmer wasn’t wrong; it had been days. She wasn’t gross or anything, but cleaning up with a washcloth over the sink wasn’t quite the same as a proper shower, and it was beginning to show. Her hair was a little greasier than usual, and she was wearing more perfume than she usually did as if she feared she *might* be getting gross. Something she often did when they were in the field and away from things like indoor plumbing.

Generally, Glimmer was the most fastidious of them. Adora had been known to transform rather than bathe when she was in a hurry; the magic always restored her skin and clothes to a clean, pristine state when she shifted back (he was pretty sure that's why her jacket was lasting so long). Bow's dads had taken him and his brothers on extended artifact hunting expeditions since before he could walk, so skipping a few days of bathing never worried him, but Glimmer hated feeling dirty.

She didn't say anything else, just kept looking down at their joined hands.

"Okay." Bow said, puzzled by the build-up. "And?"

"Would you… come with me?"

"You… want me to come shower with you?" An intrusive image of the suggestion made his mind blank out. His cheeks felt like they were on fire. They'd been making out a little, and she seemed to have a good time. Was she trying to tell him she wanted something more than cuddles?

No. Somehow Glimmer seemed nervous in exactly the wrong way for that. She wouldn't look at him; her normally warm hands were like Frosta's ice gauntlets, and she kept looking down so he couldn't see her face.

"Ah." He scrambled for a way to ask what she meant that didn't make him sound either creepy or pathetic. "W-why?" His voice cracked.

"I just don't want to be alone." Her cold hands held his in a death grip. "Especially there." She sniffed. "It reminds me too much of… Him."

Oh. So not… what he'd been kind of hoping. Also, what she said sounded ominous, but he'd come back to that later.

"Do you want me to get Adora?" he asked."That would probably be less weird."

“No." The word came out a little harshly, and Glimmer looked up finally. "She’s got… other things going on. We shouldn't bother her.”

Bow raised an eyebrow at her.

"Okay." She shifted around, and then she muttered, "I just… it really feels embarrassing that I need a babysitter." Her eyes filled with tears. “I feel bad that…” she stopped again and shook her head. “Look, I know it sounds stupid. But, please?”

He thought Glimmer and Adora were okay, but maybe not. Perhaps Adora’s ready forgiveness made Glimmer unwilling to ask for too much from her right now.

This would become (even more) awkward if they didn’t talk about ground rules. “So, uh, do you want me to just hang around outside by the sinks or..?” Darla’s bathing facilities consisted of a common shower room with eight showerheads. Outside of that was a locker room with storage shelves and several sinks.

Cheeks so red, they looked painful, Glimmer shook her head. “No. I’d be alone then.” It was true. There would be a door between them. “Look, I know. It’s ridiculous.” She let go of his hands and wrapped her arms around herself. “Nevermind.”

Bow sucked in a breath. “Okay, I'll come with you.” It wasn’t like they hadn’t slept, bathed, and everything else in close proximity before. “It’s fine. It doesn’t need to be a big deal. I can just hang out with you if it helps.”

Glimmer gave him the same grateful look she’d given him when he accepted her apology and then started walking again.

She didn’t say anything else until they went into the bunkroom, and she pulled the bag with her spare clothes from under her bed. “By the way,” she said, suddenly upbeat, as she dug through them, “thanks so much for bringing me clothes and stuff.”

“Yeah, when we decided to evacuate Bright Moon, I threw a bunch of things in a bag,” Bow told her, trying to sound off-handed. No way was Bow going to tell Glimmer that he lost his shit when word came from Micah that they were going to retreat from Bright Moon.

Adora found him crying on the floor of the Queen’s bedroom, and she crouched beside him. “We are going to find her." Dry-eyed and determined, she promised him in that I-will-fix-everything tone she had, “I promise you, I will rescue her." She told Micah the same thing three times daily.

After that, she pulled him to his feet. "When we do find her, she’ll need clothes," she told him with a decisive nod. “It’ll be nice for her to have some of her things,” she added, almost wistfully. “In case it’s a while before we come back.

Now, Bow grabbed a couple of towels from the shelf above his bed, then knowing Glimmer, he grabbed two more. She waited for him with her change of clothes.

When they got there, they stood in the locker room awkwardly until Glimmer huffed a little chuckle. “This is stupid,” she muttered. She took off her shoes and cape, stacking them on one of the shelves.

The door of the locker room opened. Catra came through. “Oh,” she said nonchalantly. “Hey.” In her arms, she carried a towel that she set on one of the shelves. She wriggled out of the shorts and bra she wore, completely ignoring that both Bow and Glimmer were there.

Or maybe not- she caught Bow’s eyes as she casually slung a towel over her shoulder. “What?” she asked, sounding a little defensive. “Did I *interrupt* something?”

“No. Nothing,” Glimmer said. “We were just talking.” She started pulling her dress off over her head.

The (naked!) magicat narrowed her eyes. “Okay.” She walked into the shower room.

Bow wanted to ask where Adora was but worried that Catra might think they were keeping watch on her. Glimmer was already wrapped up in her towel and following her. That was fast.

Now what?

"Ah, Bow?" Glimmer opened the shower room door, then turned back to Bow. Again her cheeks were red, and she wouldn’t meet his eyes. “I’ll be okay with just Catra if it’s too awkward.”

He was not okay with leaving her utterly vulnerable with “just” Catra. One rescue, a common enemy, and a couple of days did not make him inclined to trust someone who dropped him off a cliff once.

Catra stood under one of the shower heads, glaring at them. “Close the door, Sparkles,” she hissed. “You’re letting the heat out.” Glimmer slammed the door behind her. “You guys are so weird,” he heard Catra grouse.

He sighed to himself. This only had to be as weird as he wanted to make it. From his experience with Adora, Scorpia, and other Horde soldiers who joined the Rebellion after Prime’s invasion, he knew that mixed-gender bathing was a Horde thing. When Adora had come to Bright Moon, they’d had to tutor her on some of the differences in customs.

Glimmer said something to Catra that Bow didn’t catch.

“Seriously?” Catra squawked, then she laughed. “Hey, Arrow Boy!” she called out. “Are you shy? I promise I won’t bite this time.”

Okay, that was an image he didn’t need.

But also, this was the first time he’d heard Catra laugh in a way that wasn’t mean or cruel. Sure, she was teasing him, but it was positively gentle compared to what he would expect.

“If I *was* shy, that's not a lot of reassurance," he called.

The door slid open again. "Hey, Bow," Adora said, surprised. "I'm sorry, I thought Catra was in here."

"Yeah. She is," he said nervously. "Ah. So is Glimmer. " He jerked his head in the direction of the shower.

The blonde woman tilted her head, confused.

"Tell you later," Bow mouthed soundlessly.

“Okay. " She nodded and looked down at the bundle she carried. "Hey, Catra?” She raised her voice a little to be heard over the sound of running water. “Entrapta gave me some clothes for you,"

"Do they look like they’ll work?" Catra called out. "What did she even make them from?"

"Yeah. It looks okay. She found some clothes that were probably Mara's and altered them."

"Who's Mara?" Catra opened the door to see what Adora had. The blonde shook the top of the outfit out and held it up. “Oh, wow. That looks… shockingly normal.” She chuckled. “I was kind of scared.”

"Hey… ah, I… um, have some stuff to do." Bow finally said, awkwardly looking anywhere but at the naked woman standing casually in the doorway. "I'll just go do it.”

Glimmer said something else Bow didn’t catch over the water spray.

Catra's tail lashed, and then she gave Adora an unreadable look and mouthed something to her before heading back into the shower room.

“Ohh. Got it,” she replied quietly. She turned back to Bow. “It’s all right,” she whispered, pulling him out into the hallway to

talk.“We’ll stay with her.” Adora frowned worriedly. “This kind of thing usually passes after a few days.”

“Huh?” Bow asked, mystified. “What kind of thing?”

Adora shrugged. “The cadets used to call it re-entry shock.” At Bow’s blank look, she sighed. “When a cadet did something bad enough to be sent to Shadow Weaver, she usually grounded them. That meant you got locked up in a cell by yourself since we never had our own rooms. You got half or quarter rations unless Shadow Weaver was really pissed, in which case you didn’t get anything. The longest I ever did was a week.” She shuddered. “She wanted to break me of being scared of the dark. It was a few days before the light stopped giving me headaches.”

Every so often, Adora said shit like this. “Break you of…?” he choked as *so many* questions occurred to him.

“So, anyway, ” she said, cutting him off. “Catra says Prime kept Glimmer grounded the whole time he had her. That’s a long time by herself. Even with Catra coming to see her every couple of days.” She looked back towards the closed door. “We should make sure she doesn’t have to spend any time alone she doesn’t have to. Not until she’s ready to anyway.” She twisted her fingers together nervously. Something seemed to occur to Adora; her eyes widened again, and horror flowed into her expression. “Unless we interrupted something?” Her knuckles were going white as she wrung her hands together. “Oh, I’m sorry. Were you two… ?"

Bow smiled crookedly. "Ah. No. Not today."

Her shoulders dropped with relief, and she looked at the locker room door. “We should probably have some kind of signal. Like if you put a coat hanger on the door, we'd know to come back later. ”

“She didn’t want me to mention it to you,” Bow told Adora softly. “I think she's kind of embarrassed. "

She looked back at him, brows knitted and frowning. “Really? Why?”

“I don’t know. How did you know we were here, anyway?” Bow asked curiously.

“I didn’t. Catra suddenly decided that she needed a shower.”

The water turned off. Bow decided it was time for him to retreat before it got awkward again. “Yeah, I’m going to see if Darla’s all set for the night.”

“Okay.” Adora gave him an understanding smile, not calling him on his excuse.

The next morning Catra waited for him in the galley again, sitting on the bench dressed in the new clothes Entrapta made for her. “Hey,” she said, her arms crossed over her chest. “So, do you want help?”

“Sure, that’d be great.” Bow smiled at her. “Thanks!”

She didn’t return the smile. “Yeah. Whatever. This isn’t because I like you,” she muttered, more to herself than him.

As he came in to the galley, he saw the ingredients and cookware for the omelets he’d made the previous day were already neatly laid out on the counter. She had even chopped everything that needed to be chopped and the plates already set out. That was interesting, and it gave him a thought. “Do you want to learn how to make these?” he asked.

Her tail lashed but at least she didn’t seem quite as suspicious as yesterday. “Yeah. Okay.” She stood up and came to stand at his elbow.

Bow gave her a quick tutorial on how to use the stove and how to heat the pan. He narrated his actions as he mixed and poured the egg mixture into the hot pan. After the first one was finished,

Catra made the rest under his supervision. By the time the others straggled in looking for breakfast, the omelets were on the neatly laid table.

“Thanks for cooking,” Glimmer always thanked him. It was one of the things Angella had emphasized when they were growing up.

“Oh, don’t thank me,” Bow began, but Catra caught his eye. Her lips compressed, her eyes wide; she shook her head slightly. She didn’t want him to say anything. “I mean, I’m happy to do it.”

The others came in and started to eat. Catra sat tensely, not touching hers until everyone else had started. Picking up her own fork, she glanced furtively at the others.

“Did you do something different with these?” Adora asked him.

Catra visibly stiffened, her eyes flicking to him. She had done everything the way he had told her, but he knew that no two cooks produced exactly the same thing.

“Mmmmaybe.”

“It’s really good,” Adora gushed. “Like, probably the best you’ve made yet.”

Bow glanced at Catra. Her was mouth quirked up, and her shoulders relaxed. “Catra helped me with them,”

“You did?” Adora’s face lit up with a grin.

“S’not a big deal.” Catra looked determinedly at her plate, her shoulders hunched, but her cheeks turned a little pink. Her smile widened to show one fang and for the rest of breakfast, her eyes kept straying to Adora.

Chapter End Notes

> Catra has feline color blindness. It works a little differently from human colorblindness in that she has a tapetum

lucidum: the reflective layer in her retina, as evidenced by how they shine in the dark. I ran across this idea in n7punk's works (which are ALL amazing, BTW), and it has become headcanon for me.

Also treated as canon is "Don't Go" by Annacharlier

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Catra is learning to cook

Chapter Notes

I swear this was supposed to be a one-shot.

For now, this little chapter is the only follow-up.

Having Catra on the crew was weird, but Bow knew the adjustments had to be worse for her.

Over the next few days, she hovered on the edge of whatever they were doing, mostly just watching. She did seem eager to help out--she was in the galley before every meal, patiently waiting for his direction, although she confined herself to chopping ingredients and cleaning up if anyone else came in.

Bow noticed that another of her self-assigned tasks seemed to be making sure Glimmer was never alone. Every time Glimmer went to use the shower, Catra would just happen to be heading in that direction. There were other small kindnesses: a few days after escaping from Prime's forces, Bow woke up to an empty bed. Worried and wondering where Glimmer could have gone, he paced Darla's corridors until he found Glimmer and Catra in the galley eating yellow cake with white frosting right out of the baking pan.

"Where did you get the cake?" he asked, bemused. They had the ingredients, but he knew neither Adora nor Glimmer had the patience to read a recipe, put said ingredients together, and then put it in the oven. Entrapta could follow a recipe, but she would have made tiny cupcakes. Assuming she decided it was worth her time, which was doubtful.

“Catra found it. In the frozen storage.” Glimmer piped up after swallowing quickly. “Why did you guys bring it? I mean, I’m not complaining. It’s really good. But everything else is either space rations or raw ingredients.”

Bow knew that was wrong, but before he could correct Glimmer, Catra met his eyes, her mouth tight and her cheeks dark under the thin peach fuzz. “Don’t make it a big deal,” she grunted. “I just stuck it in the oven to defrost.”

Bow did not know what that was about, but if she wanted to keep things quiet, he would not out her. “You remember Entrapta’s pastry cooks?” Bow asked Glimmer smoothly. “They were in charge of supplies.” Bow did not like lying, but he was not above misdirection to keep something private.

Glimmer laughed. “And I know they know how much I like cake.”

The corner of Catra’s mouth went up, and Bow felt like he had passed some sort of test. She stood up and stretched casually. “Well, G’night Sparkles, Arrow Boy. I’m heading back to bed.” She walked out of the open door. She brushed past Bow and purposely banged her shoulder into his, hard enough to bruise.

“Hey. Ow.” He rubbed his arm. “What was that for?”

“For existing,” she grunted and rolled her eyes, but the side of her mouth still quirked up in a little smile. “Go get some cake before Adora gets here and eats it all.” She turned down the hall in the direction of her room.

“You okay?” he asked Glimmer as he sat and helped himself to a forkful of cake. It was good. “I woke up, and you were gone.”

“Sorry. I couldn’t sleep,” Glimmer said, taking another bite for herself. “I took a walk so I wouldn’t wake you, and then I heard Catra in here. She was taking the cake out of the oven.” She glanced at the door and said more quietly. “She said she has trouble sleeping. She said she didn’t mind the company.”

“Huh.” Bow shook his head, marveling at the idea that the (former?) Horde Captain would admit even obliquely to needing company. “That’s weird.”

“Yeah. I know.” Glimmer bit her lip. “She’s… complicated. I told you, we talked a lot.” She lowered her voice to a whisper. “She told me more about growing up in the Horde than Adora ever has. You know how Adora always seems like she thinks she’s always being watched and judged? I guess that was Shadow Weaver.”

Bow looked away; he had seen a little of that in the days after the evacuation of Bright Moon, and it was not pretty.

“What?” Glimmer asked, apparently catching at least some of his unspoken thoughts.

“Remember I told you your dad argued with Shadow Weaver?” Bow leaned forward, almost whispering into Glimmer’s ear, having no idea how well Catra really could hear.

Glimmer nodded.

“She kept talking about how Adora had… well… how badly Adora had fucked everything up when she broke the sword.” Glimmer pulled back, her eyes wide with shock to hear Bow swear (It was a new habit he had picked up since Prime’s invasion). He sighed. “She really spiraled after that. Well, I told you.”

“Yeah. You did.” Glimmer picked up her fork and took another bite. “She seems okay now, though.”

“I think so,” Bow said. “Or, at least, as okay as she can be with everything that is happening.”

For a few minutes, neither spoke. Glimmer sat playing with her fork and gazing off into space.

“Watcha thinking?” asked Bow, starting to get weirded out by the silence. Glimmer never just sat quietly.

“I don’t know if I understood what Adora gave up before.”

“Huh?” That seemed like a strange change of subject.

Her eyes distant, Glimmer hesitated over her words as if thinking them through as she spoke, “I never considered how hard it had to have been for Adora to leave the Horde.”

“Well, you know how she is.” Bow could not see what Glimmer was getting at. “You know she could never have stayed with them once she found out what the Horde was doing.”

"Yeah. I know. But, don’t you see? She left everything. The way Catra talked about it, Shadow Weaver wanted Adora to be her successor. You know she got promoted the day she found the sword? And she gave it all up to fight for what she believed in."

Bow nodded. "I know." It was classic Adora—making a decision and then throwing herself into it with everything she had.

"But, did you ever really think about it?" Glimmer asked, her voice sad. "She left behind everything she knew and everyone she loved on just our word. She had to start over in a new world with new people and new rules. It couldn't have been easy."

Bow smiled. "I'm glad she did it, though," he said. "Because now she's with us."

"I just never realized how hard it was," Glimmer said. "I guess I always…” She blew out her breath in a long sigh. “Shadow Weaver raised her. She must have loved her. I never thought about that before."

"You're right," Bow said slowly. His heart twisted in his chest, considering how it would be to just cut off contact with his dads like that. Even when he had been lying to them about what he was doing in Bright Moon, he never considered never talking to them again. "I guess I didn't think of that."

Glimmer's face crumpled. "After mom died… " she paused to take a breath. "I was so… I said awful things to her, and she just… took it." She looked down at the floor. "Did she tell you what I said to her after Salineas fell?"

"I-I'm not sure." Internally, Bow flinched. He knew that Adora had not told him nearly as much as she should have.

"We were arguing." She ran one hand through her lilac hair before dropping it into her lap. She still would not look up. "Well, we weren't arguing. I was just yelling at her. She said she was doing her best." She sniffed hard, and her voice shook. "I told her that… " She took a deep breath and whispered. "I told her that if her best was good enough, my mother would still be alive."

"Fuck, Glimmer…" No, Adora had not told Bow that. It was just as well. Bow had been angry enough.

"I know. I know," the distraught woman sobbed, curling in on herself.

Hesitating only a second, Bow reached out, and she collapsed into his arms.

Over Glimmer's shoulder, Bow saw Catra appear at the doorway, half-crouched as if ready for a fight, a snarl on her lips, her ears pinned back. Then she blinked, relaxing from her defensive posture. She met Bow's eyes, then nodded with something like approval. Silently, she disappeared again.

Bow had to admit that Catra's little gestures were slowly winning him over. He was beginning to see what Adora saw in the magicat. Adora was different around Catra. She smiled more, and her smiles reached her eyes. She was less anxious and somehow surer of herself.

Since the Portal incident, Adora had been brittle. First, it was all the extra pressure that Glimmer put on her and the war going badly; then, it was Prime's invasion and Shadow Weaver. It had

not been until she passed out from exhaustion that he realized how bad off she was.

He was sort of glad they were still so far away from home. While he wanted to get back and see how everyone was faring, he also thought they all needed this downtime to get themselves together.

When Glimmer finally calmed, she pulled back sheepishly. “Sorry,” she said, grabbing a napkin to wipe her face.

He held her face between both his hands. “Better?” he asked softly.

Smiling, she nodded and put her left hand over his right on her cheek, squeezing it briefly. Then she stood, brushing the crumbs off her shirt.

“Let’s go back to bed.” Bow dropped the forks into the dishwasher and covered the cake, leaving it on the counter. “It’s still too early to be up.”

At breakfast time, Catra was already in the kitchen, leaning with her elbows on the counter, reading something on a little screen in the wall, apparently so fascinated that she did not hear him coming.

“Looking for another cake recipe?” he asked.

Catra jumped and glared at him, a flash of anger kindling in her eyes. “None of your business,” she hissed, flicking the button to turn the screen off. Her ears flattened against her head, and her tail lashed. He could see the hackles on her neck go up, and there was a tremor to her hand.

The tremor made him wonder: was she… afraid of him? Bow was not used to people being scared of him. What had he done to her?

Oh, right. They had taken her hostage and tried to kill her multiple times. Come to think of it, wasn’t that why she dropped

him off a cliff in the first place? She had every reason to be scared. If Scorpia had broken him out of a Horde prison before he joined the Alliance, he probably would have been scared, at least at first.

He changed tactics. "It'd be good if you did," he said, deciding not to engage with her… whatever it was. Instead, he went on as if he had not noticed her snapping. "Glimmer ate all mine."

It was the right call. There was a little pause, and then Catra said, very quietly, "Sparkles talked a lot about cake. I wanted to try it. The instructions weren't hard." Her shoulders relaxed, and she started taking things out of the cupboards.

"Have you ever cooked before?" Bow asked, curious. According to Adora and Scorpia, rations were the only things people ate in the Horde, but Catra had mentioned contraband food the other night.

Catra shrugged. "Yeah, but it was mostly holding things over a fire on a stick. Or maybe put them on a hot rock."

"Wow." Bow was honestly impressed. "You learn really fast." He felt his brow furrow. "So why don't you want anyone to know you're learning to cook?"

"If it sucks, I'd rather not have them blame me." Catra smiled lopsidedly.

"Fair enough." Bow returned the smile. "But everything you've made has been really good."

"Yeah, okay," she muttered, taking ingredients out and putting them on the counter. "I just… don't want to talk about it. Okay?" The last word was almost snarled, and she banged the cutting board down.

For a minute, they were silent as Bow struggled to find something to say that would not piss her off, then he tried again. "Thanks for helping Glimmer."

“I didn’t do it for her,” Catra muttered, automatically it seemed.

“I didn’t mean that,” Bow hastened to tell her. “I mean… the other day when you heard her, and we didn’t. We wouldn’t have known.”

Catra scoffed and rolled her eyes. “It’s a good thing one person on this ship isn’t half-deaf .”

“Yeah, but you didn’t have to.”

The magicat paused in her cutting and sighed. Turning to Bow, she said, “I know what it’s like.” Her eyes were hollow and haunted.

“So, Prime kept you… “ Bow began, but a sharp bark of mirthless laughter cut him off.

“Prime?” Catra shuddered as she said the name. “No. That was… “ she grimaced and shook her head, bending over her task again. She quickly swiped one hand across her eyes, cleared her throat, and murmured. “Prime’s shittiness is in its own category.” She shook her head and went on more loudly. “No, it was Shadow Weaver. You wouldn’t think so, but being left alone like that fucks you up so bad that you start wishing she would just fucking zap you.”

Bow was not sure he wanted to know, but he asked anyway. “Zap you?”

Another scoff. Catra’s ears went back again. “Oh, you know. When she used the Black Garnet, you saw her do it once, only she used Sparkles’ magic.”

Bow remembered that. He also remembered the glitching thing Glimmer did after her first encounter with Shadow Weaver.

“But I guess Shadow Weaver doesn’t have her battery now, so it must be *so* hard for her,” Catra growled sarcastically, cutting the vegetables with unnecessary force. “It was one of her favorite

ways to 'enforce discipline.'" She stopped. "Usually on me," her growl was almost inaudible.

"Shadow Weaver gives me the creeps," Bow told her honestly. "She was really awful to Adora before we left."

"Well, isn't that a fucking shame?" Catra slammed the knife down on the counter, turned on her heel, and left the galley.

Bow stared at the open door, replaying the conversation in his head, trying to figure out where it got derailed. That time that Shadow Weaver took them to the Fright Zone had been so terrible. He remembered how the old witch had drained Glimmer's magic and…

Oh.

A vision of the red flashes and Catra writhing on the ground drifted to the top of Bow's mind. At the time, he was only concerned with stopping Shadow Weaver from draining Glimmer. Now, the scene took on a whole new meaning. Catra must have been out of her mind with the pain if his little taste of the Black Garnet's power was any indication.

That was right before Catra shocked Entrapta with a stun baton (Scorpia and Entrapta had both told him the story). Right before she opened the Portal. Taking over Catra's abandoned task, Bow contemplated what he had just heard. It made some of the things she did a little more understandable.

He wondered how he would have reacted if Glimmer had used magic on him when they were arguing over activating the Heart. It would not have been that farfetched. Shadow Weaver had poisoned Glimmer against listening to either Bow or Adora, convincing the young queen that the pursuit of power was the only thing that made sense. The only thing that could keep her safe.

Angella and Castaspella had not even wanted them in the same room with the old witch, and now he could understand why. Bow

had watched Shadow Weaver taking apart Adora's self-esteem bit by bit and undermining her in front of the Alliance. He was convinced that it was why Adora had gotten so reckless, trying to prove to everyone (or maybe just herself) that Shadow Weaver was wrong.

" *You made me this way!"* He remembered Catra yelling as she struggled in pain.

Adora had been raised by Shadow Weaver but she had left the Horde when she found out what they were doing. Why did Catra stay? Perhaps one day, he would ask her.

The sound of boots in the corridor announced Adora's arrival."Hey, Bow," she said. "Have you seen Catra? I thought she'd be here."

"Yeah, she said she wasn't hungry," Bow replied, not looking up, trying to sound casual. Perhaps Catra felt like she had revealed too much, which might explain why she stormed out. It felt like a breach of confidence to repeat their conversation.

The others straggled in and had breakfast. Afterward, Adora and Glimmer volunteered to clean up, so Bow told them he was going to check on something. He thought it might be a good idea to make sure Catra was okay. He wandered through Darla's corridors by himself, convinced that Catra wouldn't want them to make a big deal out of it.

Unable to find her in any of the parts of the ship they considered living quarters, Bow headed for the lower decks. On the way out, they had set up a space in the cargo bay for training. With nothing else to do, Adora needed to burn off her nervous energy. Sometimes, she literally ran off her energy by running through Darla's corridors, but sometimes, nothing would help except fighting. Entrapta had fashioned a dummy for Adora to hit, and Bow had set up a target. They also sparred with wooden swords or practiced hand-to-hand combat with each other.

Curled up in a chair at the computer station in the bay, he found Catra.

“What do you want, Arrow Boy?” she snarled. Her eyes looked puffy as if she had been crying.

“I just wanted to make sure you were okay. You seemed...,” he trailed off, unsure what a neutral term would be. He had intended to say "upset" or “angry,” but he wasn’t sure which would be easier for Catra to talk about. “Not okay.”

Several expressions flickered across Catra’s face before she settled on suspicion. “Well, I’m fine,” she said defensively. She flicked off the screen she was reading and stood up. “So, you don’t need to babysit me.”

“I know,” Bow said quietly. “I just thought you might appreciate some company.”

“I told you, I am fine. I don’t need company,” she replied through clenched teeth, and then she strode toward the door. At the last moment, she stopped and looked at her feet. She seemed to be struggling with herself, if the tension in her shoulders was any sign. She took a breath and turned back to face him. Her mouth twisted, and she bit her lip. “But it was... nice... of you to come check on me,” she added as though every word was a pulled tooth. He could see how hard she was trying.

Bow would take it.

Eavesdrop

Chapter Summary

Bow hears a conversation not meant for him

Thanks to Doc for beta-ing

Chapter Notes

I have not planned any more chapters for this, but this story still seems to want more. This scene takes place on Darla after Taking Control and before Shot in the Dark.

Bow was not *trying* to eavesdrop. Really. The sound of Entrapta's drill must have muffled his approaching footsteps, but the hallway went suddenly quiet. Before he could call out, shuffle his feet, or clear his throat, Catra's uncharacteristically hushed voice asked, "Can I ask you a question?"

Bow froze, sensing that this was not a conversation she would want overheard, but he did not want to interrupt whatever she was trying to say. He put his hand over his mouth, afraid to move. He would have turned right around and walked away, except he knew Catra would hear him.

"Sure!" Entrapta chirped. "I assume you mean a different question?"

Catra let out a long-suffering sigh. "Yes."

"Sure!"

The magicat was silent for a second, then she murmured, "Entrapta? Are we… friends?"

The pause was excruciating for Bow. He could imagine how bad it was for Catra. In the silence, his heart pounded softly in his ears over the ambient hum of the corridor. Bow's thoughts churned as

he listened. He never would have imagined that Catra worried about rejection.

"It's okay if the answer is 'no, ' " Catra growled after a minute. "It's not like I care or anything."

"Huh? Oh. I just… I'm not sure I understand what you're asking." Entrapta sounded flustered, the way she often did when feelings came up. He could imagine her blank face, blinking owlishly at Catra as she struggled to process. "Oh! Wait!" she exclaimed triumphantly, sounding as though struck by a new idea. "Are you asking because you *wanted* to be my friend again?"

"I… Look, never mind. It doesn't matter. It's stupid," the magicat muttered. Now, Bow pictured Catra's face, that almost guilty look she got sometimes when she had to ask for something. That stuttering pause usually came before a snarl and storming out of the room. He looked frantically around, but there was nowhere to hide, and she would run right into him. He hoped he could just pretend he had not heard anything.

"Well, if that is what you are asking," Entrapta said, her voice muffled. She must have put her welding mask down over her face. Her words were slow, as if she were thinking hard about them. "I *would* like to be your friend again."

"You would?" Catra sounded incredulous. "Really? Why?"

More clanking and the sound of a blowtorch. After a second, Entrapta said in her normal cheerful tone, "I like that you're so easy to talk to."

"What?" exclaimed Catra, echoing Bow's thought exactly.

"Could you hand me the six-sided hex wrench?" Entrapta asked, not answering right away. There was shuffling around momentarily, and then Entrapta slowly said, "I'm not good with people."

A soft, wet snort of agreement came from Catra.

“But I can’t help it if people don’t communicate cogently.” Entrapta sounded slightly defensive. “They talk about lots of unrelated things and expect me to pick out what they think is important. They get mad at me, and they don’t tell me. It’s just confusing, and I get so tired of having to guess.” She sighed, pausing as she chose her words. “You always let me know when you’re mad at me. And, usually, you tell me exactly why. If something is important for me to hear, you tell me and wait until I look at you so I can understand what you’re saying.”

“Huh.”

“No one ever asked me about my theories before. They get weird if they don’t understand. They don’t ask questions. You were always interested in my projects, and if you don’t understand, you don’t pretend that you do and then get mad. You, Kyle, and Scorpia… you always made me feel like I was part of the team.” Another pause. “I… never really had friends before I moved to the Fright Zone.”

“I thought the Princesses were your friends?”

“Oh. We’re friends now,” Entrapta affirmed. “But I don’t think the others would have wanted to talk to me without Adora and Bow telling them they had to.”

Bow winced. Unfortunately, that was accurate. He thought they had made Entrapta feel welcome, but maybe not as much as he thought.

“Scorpia helped a lot. She’s really good at explaining people.”

“Yeah,” Catra agreed softly. Bow was surprised at the fondness in her tone. “Scorpia’s really good at people.”

“You help with people a lot, too.” Entrapta went on thoughtfully. “I’ve observed—and appreciate—how efficient you are in your communication. It’s… comforting.” The words were awkward, full of unspoken feelings. “I can’t always tell when people want my help versus when they are just talking to hear themselves talk."

Bow winced, and regret washed over him. Layers of misunderstanding he had not seen were exposed. He thought he had done enough to make Entrapta feel included. But hearing this exchange, Bow recognized their friendship went deeper than he had ever imagined. Entrapta's tone sounded fond. This wasn't just about feeling welcome; it was about feeling seen and understood, something none of them had truly offered. How often had they made Entrapta feel left out or like her presence was unwanted?

For a long moment, the only sounds were Entrapta's metallic bangs on whatever she was working on. "I don't know what I did to make you so mad at me." she continued when she stopped banging, sounding sad. "I tried to help and then, well… I'm just not good at helping people, I guess."

"Entrapta, it's okay," Catra said hastily. "You didn't… do anything wrong. It was… that was a super bad day."

"I didn't mean just that day." Entrapta sounded as close to tears as Bow had ever heard. "I mean, you stopped talking to me. I… missed you. I tried to make things okay between you and Hordak. I just didn't want you to be mad at each other anymore."

"Oh."

There was a little silence, and then Entrapta said, "Scorpia said you were really scared when you stunned me."

"I was not scared!" Catra snarled.

"*I* didn't think you were." Entrapta went on blithely. "I'm pleased I did not misunderstand. However, I think, on average, Scorpia has a better understanding of people's reactions than I do. Like you, she can sense the chemical changes different emotions produce. Hmm."

Bow wished he could see their faces. The silence felt heavy, but that might be his own projection. Entrapta never talked about people, just her research and her gadgets. He really had very little

understanding of why she stayed with the Horde as long as she did. It was easier to understand Scorpia, who had grown up there.

"Scorpia *has* told me that fear and anger are very similar in compositions," Entrapta said slowly. "And that scent can only be used as evidence in corroboration with things like body language and expression. This is logical, given that emotions give rise to a complex admixture of pheremones that is highly vol…"

"Stop, stop, stop," Catra interrupted hurriedly. "Back to-to what we were talking about."

"Which part?"

"The part about… do you still want to be my friend?" Catra cleared her throat, sounding self-conscious.

"Oh. I thought I just told you. Yes!" Entrapta warbled. "However, I want to know what I did to make you… whatever you were. Specifically, so I can take steps not to repeat it."

Catra sighed again. "That's okay. I think I was mad at everyone. I'm sorry I took it out on you."

"You told me that. I believe you." Entrapta sounded both sincere and positive. "I am glad that we are friends again."

"Y-you are?" the magicat sounded like she could hardly believe her ears.

"Mmhm." For a moment, the noise of a drill precluded further conversation. Bow wondered if he should take the opportunity to leave without being detected, but then the drill shut off.

"Can you hold that?"

"Got it," Catra answered, followed by the sound of something being caught in one's hand. Bow could picture Entrapta tossing the tool at her without looking. Perhaps because she was

accustomed to working with Catra, she automatically expected it to be caught.

The drill whirred again and then shut off.

“Scorpia thought maybe you were jealous of all the time I spent with Hordak,” Entrapta said, her voice slow and almost vulnerable. “Is that what I did?”

Silence, then another sigh from Catra. “I just… Fuck it.” She sounded so frustrated, but Bow could hear how much she was trying to keep her emotions in check. “I got mad because I had to work so fucking hard, and you just… “ She cut herself off with a growl.

“I… took over?”

“Yeah. I guess,” Catra replied tightly.

When Entrapta spoke again, her tone was pensive. “I… never knew anyone like Hordak before,” she confessed. “I never had a lab partner before. But I guess before that… You were sort of his lab partner?”

“Something like that,” Catra muttered.

“Is that why you stopped talking to me?

The question hung in the air, charged with tension. Catra’s voice sounded strained, although her words were light when she finally responded, “That, and the whole ‘sending me to die in the Crimson Waste.” She was trying for humor, but Bow could hear a raw edge of betrayal coloring her tone.

“Oh.” There was another long pause with shuffling and clanking. “I told Hordak that you did more for the Horde than Shadow Weaver and that you should get another chance. He didn’t tell me you were supposed to die there until later.” Her tone became hard —well, as hard as Entrapta’s tone ever got. “I told him that wasn’t okay."

“Besides,” she went on in her usual cheerful tone, “I knew that obviously you and Scorpia would be fine.”

“You-you did?”

“Oh, sure. The desert is Scorpia’s natural habitat, and of course, I knew you were smarter than the criminals who lived there.”

“You actually knew there were people there?” Catra’s tone mixed incredulity with a flicker of admiration.

“Naturally,” Entrapta responded matter-of-factly. “Logical deduction. Deserters had to have gone somewhere habitable. It just made sense.”

“Oh.” It sounded like Catra was at as much of a loss as Bow.

The sound of the drill filled the corridor again; this time, it did not immediately shut off. Bow tiptoed away, each step cautious over the cold, echoing tiles of the corridor. The soft whirr of distant machinery mixed with his sigh of relief as he rounded the corner.

The conversation gave him a lot to think about. He had thought he understood them—Catra with her guarded walls and Entrapta lost in her tech. Before Scorpia had come to Bright Moon, he always took it for granted that the oblivious Entrapta had been drawn into the Horde's plans almost against her will with coercion, threats, or trickery.

Now, though? Perhaps Bow had been too quick to judge and too slow to put aside his own biases. That unsettling thought cast Entrapta’s reactions on Beast Island in a stark new light.

Appealing to her to be a better friend had not worked because they had not been particularly good friends to her in the first place. He winced when he remembered the despair in her voice when she talked about Hordak and Catra. The way she had given in to the signal after being immune to it for so long. Only when Adora had appealed to Entrapta’s voracious curiosity could she pull herself out of it.

Bow thought of how Catra cut up Entrapta's food into tiny pieces. He recalled hearing Catra snap, 'Translate, genius!' — a demand that Entrapta met not with offense but with an eager breakdown of complex ideas. It was as if Catra meant it as some kind of compliment in her harsh, gruff way. That tracked. He'd heard Catra call Adora an idiot often enough.

It hit him like a brick to the head. They all expected Entrapta to understand *them*, but no one had bothered to understand *her*. Even he had not shown any interest in Entrapta's studies except insofar as they would benefit Bright Moon. They mourned for her when they thought she was dead, yet Bow realized that they had never really known her. Of course, Entrapta had joined the Horde. They pretty much drove her there. The attempts to appeal to her better nature had fallen flat, not due to her failings, but because they had failed to be the friends she needed.

His misconceptions pressed down on him, heavy like the air before a storm. The questions stung, tinged with guilt that twined through his ribs like ivy.

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